

Not So Cutie GDD by Daniel Catt, Jadyn De Souza, Eloise Tait, Harry Webber Victor Ion



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Core Concept

Vision

We are taking the 'Cute em up' genre, juxtaposing it with a gritty dark side, and applying it to a single screen shooter! We want the player to attack cute critters and innocent childish imaginations, initially even feeling a sense of guilt. However, in time their darker side is revealed as the rounds progress, with them becoming increasingly evil.

You control an army soldier in a tank, blasting away the adorable creatures and contrasting the saturated environment.

The gameplay revolves around the player on a tank track at the bottom of the screen, with enemies spawning above the screen and descending towards them. Enemies approach in 3 forms: Rows, Waves and Levels.

We want the game to be a fun and light-hearted arcade-style button masher. Our game will stand out in this genre due to its plentiful accessibility options, quirky and fun story and a special power-up bar.

Inspiration

As we are trying to adapt the 'Cute em up' genre whilst mixing in some more evil elements, we took from a lot of different pieces of media. The art style being pixel art also lead to finding similar concepts in other media and remixing them.

- Terraria
- Doom (1993)

Design Pillars

Dichotomy – You are a killing machine, violently massacring adorable creatures in a beautiful landscape.

Single-Screen – Every part of the game will take place on one screen with no camera movement.

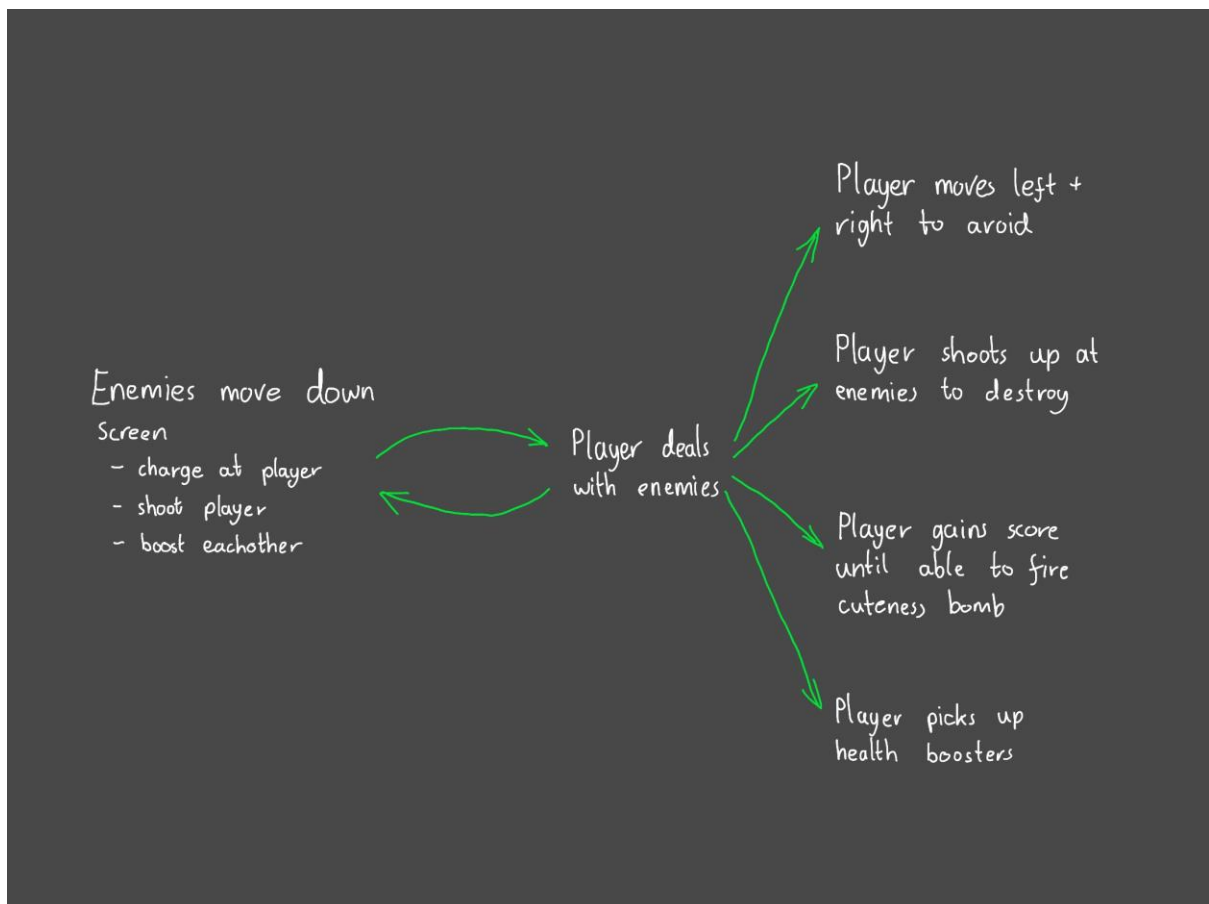
Discovery – As the levels go on and the atmosphere becomes increasingly evil, players get the sense that they have uncovered a dark truth about this fantasy land.

Destruction – The player will gain great enjoyment from the larger-than-life explosions of the enemies and gigantic cuteness bomb at their disposal.

Mechanics

Gameplay Loop

The core gameplay loop of the game is shooting the enemies that come down in Waves & Rows, moving left and right on a track. The more enemies you kill, the more score you get, more importantly though you build up a “Cuteness Overload Bar” with each enemy killed, which can blow up a lot of enemies in an area higher up on the screen.



Player

Controls:

Movement:

A / Left arrow = Left

D / Right arrow = Right

Offense:

LMB / Space = Shoot

E / RMB = Cuteness Overload Bar

Other:

ESC = Pause

Player Stats:

Damage: 1

Health: 12

Enemies

Name	Movement	Attack Style	Damage	Health	Score
Rabbit	Straight down at consistent speed.	Damage on contact.	1	1	10
Lollypop	Moves onto screen, pauses, homes in on player at fast speed.	Damage on contact.	4	1	30
Butterfly	Straight down at consistent speed.	Gives surrounding projectile-based enemies 1 extra projectile per shot. If not supporting enemy, fires single projectile.	1	1	30
Unicorn	Straight down at fast speed.	Shoots 1 projectile per shot.	1	1	40
Flower	Straight down at slow speed.	Shoots 3 projectiles per shot.	1	1	30

	Pauses when shooting.				
Tree	Straight down at very slow speed. Pauses when shooting.	Shoots 1 projectile per shot.	4	3	100

Boss

Boss Stats

Health: 140

Health Criteria: 50%, 33% 10%

Score: 2000

Boss Attacks

Name	Movement	Attack Style	Damage
Idle	Left and right slowly.	-	-
Charge	Pauses, moves quickly downwards, returns to top.	Damage on contact	4
Spit	Left and right slowly	Shoots 1 projectile per shot. After 3 shots must wait 10 seconds before shooting again.	3
Summon	Pauses, then resumes left and right movement after.	Summons 2 butterflies and 2 unicorns.	-
Eye Beam	Pauses, then resumes left and right movement after.	Shoots a beam to the bottom of the screen. Damage on contact.	12

Level Layout

Level Layout philosophy:

Hard Mode:

This was the first layout made, as the game is trying to be as difficult as possible while still being fun, much like the original SHMUP arcade games. There are strong attempts to ramp difficulty up slowly. All enemies are only introduced by the end of level 3

By level 4, now that all enemies are in play, it is more about stacking them in a challenging but fun manor. There are several levels that are stacks of easier enemies for breaks, whilst others are short but difficult to deal with enemies, intended to provide more natural breaks instead of leaving the responsibility of pausing to the player.

Easy Mode:

This mode took everything Hard mode did and toned it down where appropriate or outright went a different direction as to better make the whole experience accessible.

The early levels still introduce enemies at the same rate for the most part, but just in toned-down quantities, as enemies all have identical stats (numbers are too low to lower for easier difficulties.) Trying to not overwhelm the player was the focus.

A secondary focus was also on empowering the player. As the player has less enemies to kill, less power ups and less points to fill the cuteness overload bar, they get more consistent “break” rounds to compensate, allowing them to more easily score these rewards in stress free

environments. Requirements have also been lowered as mentioned in accessibility.

Full Level Layout:

Hard Mode:

Level	Wave	Row	Enemies
1	1	1	3 rabbit
		2	3 rabbit
	2	1	2 rabbit / 2 lolly
		2	3 rabbit / 2 lolly
	3	1	2 rabbit / 3 lolly
		2	3 rabbit / 3 lolly
		3	5 rabbit / 1 butterfly
	1	1	2 rabbit / 1 unicorn
		2	2 rabbit / 2 unicorn
2	2	1	2 unicorn / 1 butterfly
		2	6 rabbit
	3	1	2 flower / 1 butterfly
		2	1 flower / 2 rabbit / 3 unicorn
		3	2 flower / 2 butterfly / 2 unicorn
	4	1	4 flower / 1 butterfly
		2	3 flower / 1 butterfly / 2 rabbit
		3	1 flower / 1 tree / 2 rabbit
	2	1	2 tree / 2 butterfly
		2	1 flower / 3 lolly
		3	2 tree / 2 lolly
	3	1	3 flower / 2 lolly
		2	1 flower / 2 tree / 2 lolly
		3	3 rabbit / 2 tree
3	2	1	2 tree / 2 flower / 2 butterfly
		2	4 rabbit / 2 flower
		3	1 tree / 4 flower
	3	1	1 rabbit / 2 tree / 2 flower / butterfly
		2	

Level	Wave	Row	Enemies
4	1	1	6 rabbit
		2	6 rabbit
		3	4 unicorn
	2	1	2 butterfly / 3 flower
		2	2 butterfly / 3 tree
		3	4 unicorn
	3	1	1 butterfly / 3 flower
		2	2 rabbit / 4 lolly
		3	2 rabbit / 4 lolly
		4	1 flower / 1 tree
5	1	1	4 flower
		2	4 flower / 2 tree
		3	2 unicorn / 2 flower
		4	1 rabbit / 2 lolly / 2 unicorn
	2	1	6 rabbit
		2	6 lolly
		3	6 butterfly
		4	6 unicorn
	3	1	3 flower / 3 tree
		2	6 flower
		3	6 tree
		4	2 butterfly / 2 flower / 2 tree

Easy Mode:

Level	Wave	Row	Enemies
1	1	1	2 Rabbit
		2	2 Rabbit
	2	1	2 Rabbit / 1 lolly
		2	2 Rabbit / 1 lolly
	3	1	3 Rabbit / 1 lolly
		2	2 lolly
2	1	1	1 rabbit / 1 unicorn
		2	1 rabbit / 1 unicorn
	2	1	1 unicorn / 1 butterfly
		2	4 rabbit
	3	1	1 butterfly / 1 flower
		2	1 rabbit / 2 unicorn / 1 flower
3	1	3	2 butterfly / 1 flower / 1 unicorn
		2	2 rabbit / 3 flower
	2	2	2 rabbit / 1 tree
		1	2 lolly / 1 flower
	3	2	2 tree
		3	2 flower / 2 tree
4	1	1	1 butterfly / 2 flower
		2	2 rabbit / 2 unicorn
	2	3	2 tree / 2 flower
		4	3 rabbit / 1 butterfly / 1 flower / 1 tree
	3	1	4 rabbit
		2	5 rabbit
5	1	3	6 rabbit
		1	2 butterfly
	2	2	3 flower / 1 tree
		3	3 unicorn
	3	1	1 butterfly / 3 flower
		2	4 rabbit / 2 butterfly
		3	4 butterfly / 1 flower
		4	1 flower / 1 tree
	1	1	4 rabbit
		2	4 butterfly
	2	3	4 lolly
		1	4 unicorn
		2	3 flower
		3	3 tree
	3	1	2 flower / 3 tree
		2	4 tree
		2	2 butterfly / 2 flower / tree

- There are 5 total levels, they vary in both Wave & Row number, each Row is capped at 6 enemies, so the player does not get overwhelmed

- Each level is predetermined, meaning the player simply has to “Survive the gauntlet”

- The Cuteness Overload Bar charges with each enemy killed by 20 points, this is the same for every enemy EXCEPT the boss. The bar needs 800 total points to be fired *and you are capped at 3 charges*.

Power-Ups

The game will feature one randomly spawning health power-up. After killing an enemy there is an 8% chance for the power-up to spawn. It will float down towards the player, and if they contact it, they are granted 3 points to their health bar.

The game will also include a special attack power. This will be presented as a bar which fills by varying amounts based on each enemy killed, and by each hit on the boss. Once the bar is filled the player will be able to use this attack at any time of their pleasing. After the attack had been used the bar will be reset to zero. The attack will consist of a large bomb which kills enemies it contacts in a 3x3 grid.

Power-up	Benefit	Obtain?
Health	Fully restores health	Every enemy has 8% chance to drop on death / Floats down / Stops at player / Dissapears after 5 seconds of stopping
		Cuteness bar
		Bar needs 80 points to fill
		Enemies give 2 points for bar on death
		Each hit on boss gives 2 points for bar
		Activation of bar creates bomb which kills enemies in a 3x3 grid infront of player

Player-Versus-Player

The game will include a PVP mode where players battle against each other to survive the longest. Players will appear side-by-side on the screen and waves of enemies will come down on each side. The two players will share a keyboard, with one player using WAD and space and the other using the arrow keys and enter. The aim of the battle is to survive against the oncoming enemies the longest.

Accessibility:

In creating this game we have attempted to try and tick off as many accessibility options from the [Games Accessibility Guidelines](#) as possible:

Motor:

“Include an option to adjust the game speed.”

While game speed itself cannot be adjusted, we allow players to progress between levels at their own pace by having a ‘shoot to continue’ prompt.

“Ensure controls are as simple as possible, or provide a simpler alternative.”

Our controls are very limited and straightforward. We have tried to keep all controls to how they are mapped as standard in other games. In total there are only 2 inputs for movement, one for attacking and one for using the cuteness bomb.

“Include an option to adjust the sensitivity of controls”

We to have a slider in the game options where the left and right movement sensitivity can be adjusted.

“Avoid repeated button inputs.”

We have included an option in the settings where auto-firing can be turned on and off, so that players do not have to mash buttons to shoot if they do not wish to.

Cognitive:

“Use simple and clear language.”

All of our text in-game consists of single words or very short sentences. Wherever possible we have attempted to use symbols instead of language to make the UI even more accessible.

“Use simple clear text formatting.”

We have created our own font for the game which is very clear and easy to read. We have also made all text elements very large and highly contrasting with whatever background they are on to improve legibility.

“Use an easily readable default font size.”

All of our text is in very large lettering, making it easily viewable on any screen.

“Ensure no essential information (especially instructions) is conveyed by text alone, reinforce with visuals and/or speech.”

As mentioned before, where possible we have replaced text prompts with images, such as showing a visual of which key to press rather than having text to explain.

“Indicate / allow reminder of controls during gameplay.”

During gameplay once the cuteness bar fills up an E symbol appears, reminding the player that they must press this key to fire the bomb.

“Provide separate volume controls or mutes for effects, speech and music.”

Within our settings menu we have two separate sliders, one to control music volume and one to control sound effect volume.

“Avoid flickering images and repetitive patterns.”

We know that some players can experience motion sickness during screen-shakes, so hope to include an option to disable them.

We also plan to localise most if not all the game into two languages

- Spanish
- Romanian

There are going to be some struggles with this, such as changing the UI, meaning the UI designer will have to work closely with the accessibility team to get proper translations, as well as making a font and then having text fill from the translators.

Vision:

“Provide high contrast between text/UI and background.”

All of our text and UI elements are highly contrasting to their backgrounds. For UI many of the colours used do not appear anywhere in the background. For text we mostly use bright white text to contrast with background colour.

Difficulty:

The game will have two difficulty options.

Firstly, the name “Easy” - we do not like the idea of this. Inspired from some controversy heard from online chatter, players sometimes feel belittled by difficulty titles, and this game has no intent of dissuading the ability to play it, so we are keeping it fitting with the game, calling it a difficulty option as to make it clear the affect, but not belittling the player by calling it something akin to “Cutie Mode” whilst the harder mode will have something like “Gruesome Mode” and the UI will be more red and bloody.

Secondly there are a number of changes to this easier difficulty, starting with health, your health is doubled from the base game up to 24 (still being workshopped, may change in final product!). The Cuteness Overload Bar (COB) charge is lowered to 600 and Health drops multipliers will be increased!

Mechanics:

The Cuteness overload bar is designed specifically to be simple to understand, both visually and mechanically. You should be able to easily understand what is happening as it increases, activation is a simple button press, and the effect should be clear through visual feedback.

Art Direction:

What is the artistic direction of the game?

We want to blend a mix of cute and ugly/off-putting. Certain elements will be incredibly adorable and try to lead the player into a false sense of security, but then they change and become more gruesome. The game is supposed to be constantly juxtaposing itself in as many facets as possible.

The Enemies that will pop up throughout the levels will all be childlike ideas of what is cute, Bunnies, lollypops and unicorns - things must feel juvenile and childish. Once the enemies have been around for a couple of waves, they start to show their more demonic side, with animations transitioning into more evil variants.

The world should be a lovely grass forest, something ripped straight from a fantasy world, but a safe, happy fantasy, it should feel bright and colourful.

Style Guide

- Characters are 32x32 pixels
- The boss is 128x128 pixels
- Screen resolution and background size is 400x300 pixels
- Colour palette can be found [here](#) (saturation and brightness can be changed but these are the main colours of the game).

#000000	#1D2B53	#7E2553	#008751
#AB5236	#5F574F	#C2C3C7	#FFF1E8
#FF004D	#FFA300	#FFEC27	#00E436
#29ADFF	#83769C	#FF77A8	#FFCCAA

- Elements have no black outline and little shading.

- Text should be white (font can be found [here](#))

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U
 V W X Y Z
 a b c d e f g h i j k l m n o p q r s t u v
 w x y z
 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 0

- Walking animations should be mostly 4 frames

- Shooting animations should be mostly 2 frames

- Key words: Cute, Childlike, Adorable, Off-putting, Disgusting, Demonic



Cutting Room Floor:

Design Ideas:

Cuteness Overload Bar:

It was originally intended to have 3 different abilities, all growing in strength and utility as you unlock more. This had to be toned down due to scope.

PVP:

PvP was supposed to be literal, fighting another player on the other end of the screen, this was not focused enough by the designer and had to be changed due to scope.